

HMXXX, Introduction to Speculative Fiction and Films (Autumn 2025)

Course Placement: B.Tech. (ICT, CS and MnC), Open Elective, Semester – VII

Course format: 3 hours of lectures each week.

Course Instructor: Satvik Gupta, 3204, Faculty Block 3

Course Content:

This course introduces the speculative fiction supergenre by focusing on its five representative subgenres: fantasy, science fiction, horror, dystopian and post-apocalyptic fiction. The objective is to examine the supergenre's historical, cultural, and philosophical underpinnings while exploring the themes of wonder, dread, technological hubris, tyranny and human resilience. By the end of this course, learners will be able to recognize and appreciate works of speculative fiction while engaging in critical discourse and analysis of representative texts and films.

Note: Films only constitute 25% of the course content, the remaining 75% includes intensive reading of short stories, novels, essays and research papers.

Course Objectives:

- To recognize and appreciate works of horror, science fiction, fantasy, dystopian fiction and post-apocalyptic fiction.
- To position and understand works of speculative fiction within a larger cultural, historical, and socio-political context.
- To encourage learners to engage in discourse related to speculative fiction.

Course Material (Selected):

Primary Readings:

Tolkien, J. R. R. "On Fairy-Stories." *Tolkien on Fairy-Stories*. Harper Collins, 2014, pp. 27-84 (Select excerpts).

Borges, Jorge Luis. "The Library of Babel." *Ficciones*, A.A. Knopf, 2000, pp. 58–66.

Clarke, Arthur C. "The Nine Billion Names of God." *The Collected Stories of Arthur C. Clarke*, Orion, 2011.

Asimov, Isaac. "Robot Dreams." *The Complete Stories Vol. 2*, Harper Collins, 1997.

Lovecraft, H. P. "The Call of Cthulhu." *The Call of Cthulhu and Other Weird Tales*, Vintage Classic, 2011, pp. 61–98.

Poe, Edgar Allan. "The Fall of the House of Usher." *The Fall of the House of Usher and Other Writings*, edited by David D. Galloway, Penguin, 2003, pp. 90–109.

Orwell, George. *Nineteen Eighty-Four*. Penguin Books, 2003 (Select excerpts).

Jackson, Shirley. "The Lottery." *The Lottery and Other Stories*, Penguin Books, 2009, pp. 291-302.

Bradbury, Ray. "There Will Come Soft Rains." *The Martian Chronicles*, Simon & Schuster Paperbacks, 2017.

McCarthy, Cormac. *The Road*. Picador collection, 2022.

Films:

Miyazaki, Hayao, director. *Spirited Away*. Studio Ghibli, 2001.

Villeneuve, Denis, director. *Arrival*. Paramount Pictures, 2016.

Peele, Jordan, director. *Get Out*. Universal Pictures, 2017.

Joon Ho, Bong, director. *Snowpiercer*. CJ Entertainment, 2013.

Additional Readings:

Asimov, Isaac. "Nightfall." *Nightfall and Other Stories*, Fawcett Publications, 1969, pp. 11–44.

Atwood, Margaret. *The Handmaid's Tale*. Vintage, 1996.

Carroll, Noël. "Why Horror?" *The Philosophy of Horror, or, Paradoxes of the Heart*, Routledge, 1990, pp. 158–215.

Jackson, Shirley. *The Haunting of Hill House*. Penguin Books, 2009.

Shelley, Mary. *Frankenstein: Or the Modern Prometheus*, Oxford University Press, 2008.

Additional Films:

Weir, Peter, director. *The Truman Show*. Paramount Pictures, 1998.

"When You're Lost in the Darkness." *The Last of Us*, written by Craig Mazin and Neil Druckmann, directed by Craig Mazin, PlayStation Productions, 2023.

Note: Narratives/films beyond the prescribed course material may also be discussed in the class.

Evaluation plan:

1. Attendance and Classroom Participation: 10%
2. Classroom Presentations: 20%
3. Written Assignment/Term paper: 30%
4. End Semester Exam: 40%

Course Outcomes:

Upon the completion of the course, it is expected that the students will be able to:

- Recognize and analyze recurrent speculative fiction motifs, themes and modes of expression.
- Demonstrate a critical understanding of the supergenre's impact on contemporary and popular culture.
- Develop informed arguments on the intersections of literature and cinema within the sphere of speculative fiction.

P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P6	P7	P8	P9	P10	P11	P12
			X		X	X	X	X	X		X

Detailed Course Contents		
Topic/Content		No. of lectures
1.	Understanding Speculative Fiction	7
2.	Fantasy (Readings and Films)	7
3.	Science Fiction (Readings and Films)	7
4.	Horror Fiction (Readings and Films)	7
5.	Dystopian Fiction (Readings and Films)	7
6.	Post-Apocalyptic Fiction (Readings and Films)	7
Total Lectures		42